

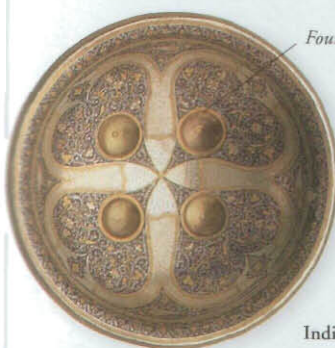
ARMS AND ARMOUR



WARRIORS OF THE PAST attacked with slashing swords, sharp spears, flying arrows, deadly axes, and crushing clubs. All of these arms, or weapons, could kill, so fighters protected themselves with armour: tough coverings of wood, leather, or metal. The invention of firearms in the 14th century made armour useless, because metal plates thick enough to deflect bullets were too heavy to wear. By the 16th century, arms and armour were strictly for show. Modern soldiers may still wear shiny breastplates and carry swords or spears on parade, but they swap them for guns and bullet-proof vests on the battlefield.

Arms

The simplest arms – clubs – are extensions of a fighter's fist, delivering a knock-out punch from a greater distance. Most hand arms, however, aim to wound by cutting the body. Swords, daggers, and lances do this for hand-to-hand fighting; arrows and boomerangs do it from afar, killing or injuring foes that may be almost out of sight.



Four circular bosses covered the handle attachment.

Defensive weapons

Shields are used for defence. Prehistoric hunters may have invented them as camouflage when hunting. Later fighters strapped shields to their left arms to fend off sword cuts. Wood and leather shields were light, and strong enough to deflect all but a direct sword thrust.

Indian shield

Boomerang

Parrying shield

Crescent-shaped blade

Tabars, Indian steel axes

Tiger heads studded with gems.

Mughal dagger

Sheath

Attacking weapons

Over the centuries, warriors have used various weapons for different kinds of fighting. Sabres (curved swords) delivered the deadliest cuts, but straight swords were better for thrusting strokes. Clubs and axes had to be heavy and sharp, yet short enough to swing easily. Small, easily hidden daggers were often used for secret assassinations.

Aboriginal weapons

Shamshir, a classic Indian sabre



A mace was effective against plate armour.

Benin warrior

Soldiers of this great 15th-century African empire wore heavily quilted garments as armour. Light bamboo shields were easy to carry and protected warriors from glancing blows from iron-tipped spears or javelins.

Benin bronze plaque

Armour

A suit of armour had to protect against weapons, yet it also had to be comfortable enough to wear all day. Different cultures used various materials, such as leather or metal, to achieve these aims.



Pauldron and besagew protect shoulder and armpit.

Bevor protects lower face.

Samurai, 1300s



Japanese samurai

Samurai armour was made of many small metal or leather scales laced together with coloured silks. Armour became more decorative when firearms removed its protective value.

European knight

Knights wore chain mail (linked metal rings) to protect them. In the 14th century, armourers introduced metal plates (plate armour) for extra protection.

European knight, 1300s

Full armour for a horse weighed 34 kg (75 lbs).

Tassels on headpiece protected the horse's face from flies.

Charm made of copper bells.

Spike

Italian horse armour, 1570

Gilt

Leather saddle

Animal armour

African horse armour, such as that of the Fulani people of West Africa, was quilted cotton stuffed with kapok. During battle, horses also wore chain mail across the flanks and around the head. In Europe, metal horse armour was expensive, and knights often armoured only their horses' heads.

Fulani horse armour

Modern armour

Artificial fabric, such as nylon, provides soldiers and police officers with more protection than thick metal armour. Bullet-proof vests are made of 16 or more layers of nylon. A bullet flattens when it hits the outer layer; lower layers slow it down so that the wearer is bruised, rather than killed or seriously injured.



Riot police

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